The Rite of the Feast Gathering

Gaṇacakravidhi · Toh 1231 · Derge Tengyur
ཚོགས་ཀྱི་འཁོར་ལོའི་ཆོ་ག

The Rite of the Feast Gathering, known in Sanskrit as the Gaṇacakravidhi and in Tibetan as Tsokkyi Khorlö Choga, is a short ritual manual in verse attributed to the Indian master Ḍombi Heruka and translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Jñānākara with the translator Marpa Lodrö. Opening with homage to the glorious Vajraḍākinī, it sets out how to hold a tantric feast gathering (gaṇacakra), praised as a supreme means of completing the accumulations of merit and wisdom: when and where to hold it, how to choose the presiding master and the participants, how to prepare and bless the food and offerings, and how the rite unfolds through its successive "wheels" of body, speech and mind, ending with dedication and the request for the deities to depart. It is Toh 1231 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the commentaries and ritual works on the Buddhist tantras.

In the language of India: gaṇacakrabidhināma. In the language of Tibet: The Rite of the Feast Gathering.

Homage to the glorious Vajraḍākinī.

Sky-colored, stainless, you sport in full and perfect union;
trampling the four māras beneath your feet, you guard the world well.
To that excellent and terrifying chief of the ḍākinīs I bow,
and so that beings may fully gather the accumulation of merit,
the great feast praised as supreme in all the tantras, which burns the afflictions,
its concise rite, the play of skillful means and wisdom, I shall explain.

Now first, one who wishes to hold a feast,
following with understanding,
with faith that is wholly clear,
should take up the guru and the chosen deity.

The cause of attaining buddhahood
is the accumulations of merit and wisdom;
from the accumulations the supreme accomplishment arises;
therefore one should always gather the accumulations.
This is the direct realization of wisdom.
Although there are many kinds of merit,

enjoying the five sense pleasures
through the wheel of one's own deity is unsurpassed.

Therefore, for its rite,
the eighth, the fourteenth
and the fifteenth of the waxing fortnight are highly praised;
likewise on the eighth,
the fourteenth and the fifteenth of the waning fortnight
the wise should turn the wheel.

In a charnel ground, or at a solitary tree,
in a pleasure grove or a monastery,
likewise in one's own house,
or in other secluded houses,
smear the ground with the five products of the cow
and strew various fragrant flowers.

Now first, one who wishes to hold the feast
should approach, as master of the feast, a monk
who knows many tantras,
is diligent in yoga and free of conceptual thought,
knows the ten principles, has great compassion,
keeps the sacred commitments and has few desires;
or else, to a master of that kind,
beginning with the generation of the mind of awakening, one should make the formal request.
Then also others who keep the sacred commitments,
who are devoted to the guru and of few conceptions,
without grudges or quarrels, and with faith of their own,
people as many as the number of the deities, should be invited.

In order to delight the guests,
meat and beer,
cooked rice, sweets and cakes,
likewise foods to eat and to chew,
to drink, and likewise to lick and to savor:
with worldly wealth
prepare the feast as far as one's means allow.
Likewise incense, ointments,

perfumes and the finest flower garlands,
lamps and various fumigants should be set out.

Then the master, on a fine seat,
sits properly in the center.
Likewise on fine seats
the wheel of yogins should be arranged on the right,
and that of yoginīs on the left.
Then the master himself,
with the vajra and with marks,
at the three places of body, speech and mind,
should bless everyone.
Likewise with the finest flower garlands
their headdresses and necklaces are adorned.
Then, with the water of excellent nectar,
all the food should be mixed.

The work that the chief performs is this:
imagine the vessels as skull cups arising from a;
then imagine the five nectars,
and further, from hūṃ visualize a vajra.
Below that, the wind and fire of action
are kindled, and the vajra falls into the skull cup;
by this, imagine it as the nectar of the deities.
When the nectar has arisen, recite the mantra as well.
Or else, from the vajra
light rays radiate, by which the nectar
of wisdom is summoned, and with wisdom
the three are mixed into a single taste;
this is called vajra nectar,
and one recites the mantra of intrinsic purity as well.
These are held to be
the first part of the feast gathering.

Then the yoginīs,
in the seat of water, from raṃ,
imagine luminosity within a blaze.
In its center, from vaṃ, an eight-petaled lotus;
upon it imagine the wheel of deities.

Imagining the mouth as the fire-offering pit,
visualize the two hands, from hūṃ,
as two vajra ladles.
Each imagines themselves as their own deity.
In the manner of vajra recitation,
with a nonconceptual mind, recite the secret mantra.
This definitive inner yoga
is said to be called the wheel of the mind.
This is held to be
the second part of the feast gathering.

Then the lord of the feast (gaṇapati)
should make a maṇḍala before each one.
After that, before everyone, the feast of offerings,
wholly pure, is set out.
Holding flowers, standing in front,
having generated the mind toward awakening, one prays:
"Vajradhara and all, please turn your minds to me!
As I offer this special feast
with a mind of faith,
please accept it as you please."
Having prayed with such words,
one should scatter the flowers.

Then the chief says to the deities:
"How wonderful, great beings of wisdom!
The great feast, blazing, burns the afflictions."
Having attained such bliss,
all say aho sukha.
Then, unhurried, with one voice,
these mantras should be recited:
aho sukha bhakṣanāṃ aho sukha prāyanāṃ mahāmudra siddhina prapathata nirate na hūṃ ha ha ho

Then, from the first yoga,
fully endowed with the sound of hūṃ
and fully endowed with the five mudrās,
taking up nectar with the ladle,
one should burn it within the blaze.

Into a skull cup made of a single piece,
having filled it with nectar,
the yoginī should offer it to the chief
with the lotus mudrā.
Likewise passing it around
from one to the next is the wheel of mudrā;
these are held to be
the third part of the feast gathering.

Then the chief should accomplish
the profound Dharma through meditative equipoise.
With that vajra one should arouse bliss.
So that, through the assemblies of great bliss,
the patron may gather the accumulations,
the profound Dharma is to be proclaimed, it is said.
Thus the gathering of skillful means and wisdom
speaking the Dharma in its proper order
is the wheel of speech of the true Dharma.

Then, urged on by the chief,
with play free of conceptual thought,
if the partners of skillful means sing songs of wisdom,
or else the reverse is done,
that is the wheel of body and speech.
In the proper order of these,
all should turn the wheel.

Then, taking turns with one another,
the patron, for the sake of offering,
offers his own wife,
or other women besides,
women of beauty; or else
a yogin who desires merit
should make the request to the chief.

Then the chief, in order that all the deities
may abide in the sacred commitment,
through the yoga of great bliss
embraces closely within a curtained space,

and entering union on a comfortable seat,
for as long as he abides in bliss,
for that long the three realms are empty.
Having made them one with the mind,
and having taken the camphor with the tongue,
to all the deities the drops
are given into the lotus of the mouth.
That is the bliss of wisdom;
one should enter the wheel of enjoyment.
Thus, in due order,
there all the deities without exception,
through the stage of self-blessing,
entering union on comfortable seats,
eat their own nectar themselves.
That bliss is truly known through skillful means.
Whatever bliss of mind arises
is held to be the wheel of mind.

If these are not fully accomplished,
with medicine and the essence of butter
one anoints the heart
and gently massages it a little.
That too is great bliss of mind,
and is certainly the wheel of mind.

Thus the gathering in thorough union,
through the yoga of each one's own deity,
having offered enjoyments as a gift:
gold, jewels and the like,
silk and cotton cloth, or else medicine,
to the chief and to the wisdom partner of bliss equally,
to them twice as much as to the others,
and to the others half of that,
the patron should request the dedication of virtue.
With a maṇḍala together with flowers,
and holding flowers in the hand,
one should speak these words:
"Vajradhara and all, please turn your minds to me!

With great faith in you
I have offered this assembly of offerings;
may I and all sentient beings to the farthest limit, without exception,
abandon the suffering of saṃsāra
and become the victorious Vajradhara of great bliss!"

Then, to gladden him,
the chief should speak these words:
"How wonderful, great being!
Today the buddhas
fully turn their minds to you.
Since you will become a buddha,
you see the great fruit;
with confidence, strive!"
These are the basis of merit.

Then, burning the leftovers and the first portion,
the torma for all the bhūtas
is sent out by the yogin perfect in yoga.
Having gathered up the flowers and the rest,
the marks should be wiped away.
The yoga of each one's own deity,
through meditative concentration, mantra and mudrā,
is requested to depart for the benefit of beings.

Then the chief, to the assembly of deities,
in order to teach the sacred commitment, says:
"Seeing the sufferings of the hells and the rest,
do not speak of this practice."

By whatever stainless virtue I have gained
through performing the feast,
may all beings gather
the two accumulations and attain the state of Vajradhara!

The Rite of the Feast Gathering, composed by the venerable master Ḍombi Heruka, is complete. It was translated by the Indian preceptor Jñānākara and the translator Marpa Lodrö.

Translator's Notes

• The text reads "pa yi lnga" for the substance smeared on the ground; this is evidently a slip for "ba yi lnga", the five products of the cow (pañcagavya), and is translated so. "Thod" in the line on adorning with garlands is taken as headdress or forehead ornament rather than skull cup, since participants are being adorned; the skull cups proper are "thod pa" in the following lines. "Tshogs kyi bdag po" here is the presiding master of the feast (gaṇapati), not the god Gaṇeśa. "Seat of water" (chu gnas) is most likely the belly or navel region where the inner fire offering is visualized.
• The line on the song is elliptical in the Tibetan ("of method, if, wisdom song"); it is taken to mean that the male partners sing songs to the female partners of wisdom, or the reverse. "Camphor" (ga pur) and "nectar" in the union section are the tantric code terms for the generative fluids, and "lotus of the mouth" renders "lotus of the face".

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.